

Trifles

- Susan Gilaspell

- Understanding the text

Answer the following questions.

a) Do you believe that Mrs. Wright killed her husband? Explain.

Ans: Yes, I believe Mrs. Wright killed her husband. The ~~to~~ strangled bird found in her ~~sex~~ sewing box symbolizes her husband's death. Years of loneliness and emotional abuse from Mr. Wright made her life joyless and silent. When he killed her only source of happiness - the bird - it became her final breaking point. The evidence and her disturbed state show she acted out of long-suppressed anger and kill his husband same as he killed the bird.

b) Do you think Mr. Wright's death ~~de~~ would have been uncovered if Mr. Hale hadn't stopped by the Wrights' home?

Ans: No, Mr. Wright's death might not have been uncovered so soon if Mr. Hale hadn't stopped by. The Wrights lived in isolation, far from neighbours, and no one visited them often. Mr. Hale's vi-

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sit to discuss telephone installation accidentally revealed the murder when he found Mr. Wright's body. Without his arrival, the body could have remained undiscovered for days, as Mrs. Wright seemed detached and unbothered.

c. Why does Mrs. Hale think that Mrs. Wright's worries about her preserves indicate her innocence?

Ans Mrs. Hale thinks that Mrs. Wright's concern for her preserves shows she wasn't thinking like a guilty person. Mrs Hale notice that Mrs. Wright was very worried about her jars of fruit preserves. This shows she was thinking about small household matters, not about planning or hiding a crime. A guilty person would focus on the murder, not frozen jars. Her concern shows she was confused, not cruel or calculating. So, Mrs. Hale thinks this worry is a sign that Mrs. Wright didn't plan the murder in a cold, deliberate way.

d. How does Mrs. Peters' homesteading experience connect her to Mrs. Wright?

Ans Mrs. Peter knows what it is like to live alone on a farm and feel lonely

and sad. She also experienced loss and hardship, so she can understand Mrs. Wright's feelings. This shared experience makes her sympathize with Mrs. Wright ~~to~~. She sees why Mrs. Wright might have felt trapped, isolated, and desperate which helps her understand the reasons behind Mrs. Wright's actions, even if she doesn't openly say them.

e. How do the women's perspectives on men differ?

Ans. The women notice details that men ignore, which they call "trifles." Men think these small things are unimportant, but the women understand that they reveal important emotions and problems. Women see how men underestimate them and fail to understand feelings or struggles. Their perspective focuses on empathy and understanding, while men focus only on facts, rules, and authority. This difference helps the women uncover the truth that men overlook.

• Reference to the ~~text~~ Content

A. Read the extracts given below and answer the questions that follow.

a. "~~How~~ happy ~~we~~ ~~were~~ ~~there!~~"

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a. "MRS. PETERS: (glancing around). Seems funny to think of a bird here. But she must have had one, or why would she have a cage? I wonder what happened to it?"

MRS. HALE: Is' pose maybe the cat got it."

i. Who does 'she' refer to?

Ans 'She' refers to Mrs. Wright (Minnie Foster).

ii. What does the word 'one' stand for?

Ans The word 'one' stands for strangled bird.

iii. What is the full form of "s' pose"

Ans The full form of "s' pose" is suppose.

iv. What do you mean when Mrs. Hale says, "the cat got it"?

Ans I mean the cat ate the strangled bird when Mrs. Hale says, "the cat got it"?

b. "Mrs. Hale: Wright was close. ----- She used to wear pretty clothes and be lively, when she was Minnie Foster, one of the town girls singing in the choir. But that - oh, that was thirty years ago."

i. Why does Mrs. Hale refer to Mrs. Wright as "Minnie Foster"?

Ans Mrs. Hale calls Mrs. Wright "Minnie Foster" to remind us of her lively, young self

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before marriage or to remember how she was before marriage, when she was lively and happy.

ii. What does her description tell you about Mrs. Wright?

Ans. It shows that Mrs. Wright used to be cheerful and friendly, but now she is quiet and lonely because of her married life.

iii. What does Mrs. Hale mean by "that was thirty years ago"?

Ans. "That was thirty years ago" means a long time has passed and her life has changed a lot since then.

c. What is the main theme of the play?

Ans. The main theme of Trifles is the loneliness and suffering of women in a male-dominated society. Men often ignore women's feelings, thoughts, and problems, thinking they are unimportant. Mrs. Wright's life shows how isolation and neglect can destroy happiness.

Before marriage, Mrs. Wright was cheerful and loved singing, but her husband was cold and joyless. This made her quiet, sad, and lonely. Her life in the farmhouse rep-

resents the emotional imprisonment that many women faced at that time.

Mrs. Hale and Mrs. Peters understand her pain and secretly support her by hiding evidence. Their act shows the strong bond and understanding between women. Glaspell's play teaches that small "trifles" can reveal big truths about women's suffering, strength, and silent struggle for justice.

d. Discuss the symbolism used in the play.
Ans Trifles uses symbols to show hidden meanings. The dead bird represents Mrs. Wright's lost happiness and spirit, while the birdcage shows her trapped and joyless life. A broken cage door shows her desire to be free.

The quilt represents her disturbed mind and mental tension. Its uneven stitching shows her anxiety and worry. The messy kitchen, which men mock, symbolizes neglect, loneliness, and emotional emptiness.

Glaspell shows that small household items, often seen as ~~trifles~~ "trifles", actually carry deep meaning. Each object tells a

Story about Mrs. Wright's suffering, her inner struggles, and hidden strength. These symbols help the audience understand the emotional world of women, which men usually ignore.

e. Discuss the setting of the play. Does it have an impact of the theme.

Ans The setting of the play Trifles is the kitchen of the Wrights' farmhouse in a lonely rural area, during the early 1900s. This time period shows ~~when~~ when women had very limited rights and were mostly confined to household duties. The cold and gloomy kitchen reflects Mrs Wright's sad and lonely life.

The messy and unfinished household work, like dirty towels and broken jars, shows her mental disturbance and unhappiness. While the men laugh at the untidy kitchen, the women understand it as a sign of deep emotional pain and neglect. The setting silently tells the story of Mrs. Wright's suffering.

Thus, the setting plays a very important role in the play. It mirrors Mrs. Wright's inner world - cold, quiet, and trapped. Showing women's isolation and their silent struggle for freedom.

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- Reference beyond the text

a. The Credibility of a character is determined not only by the character's thoughts and actions but also by what other characters say and think about him or her. Discuss in relation to the characters of Trifles.

Ans The credibility of a character is shown not only through their own actions but also by what others say and think about them. In trifles, Mrs. Wright's character is revealed through the words and opinions of Mrs. Hale and Mrs. Peters. She never appears on stage, yet we understand her life and emotions from what others say about her. ~~This shows~~ ≠

The women recall her as "Minnie Foster," a cheerful girl who loved to sing in the choir. But after marrying Mr. Wright, she became lonely and silent because of his cold and strict nature. Her life in the farmhouse turned dull and joyless.

Through these conversations, we realize her deep suffering and emotional pain. Susan Glaspell uses others' voices to make Mrs. Wright's character real and believable. It helps the audience understand how neglect, loneliness, and a lack of love can destroy a woman's happiness and mental peace.

b. Dramatic irony occurs when the reader or audience has information that is unknown to the characters in a play; it creates tension and suspense. Analyse the play discussing the author's use of dramatic irony based on these questions:

- What information is crucial to the play triffles?
- How does the playwright use this information to create dramatic irony?
- What effect does the dramatic irony have on the audience and on the ~~play~~ play?

Ans. In triffles, the crucial information is the discovery of a dead bird hidden in Mrs. Wright's sewing box. This clue reveals the motive for the murder - Mr. Wright killed her bird, and in grief and anger, she killed him.

The playwright creates dramatic irony because the audience and the two women, Mrs. Hale and Mrs. Peters, know the truth, but the men do not. The men keep mocking the women for paying attention to "triffles," unaware that these small clues solve the mystery.

This creates tension and interest in the play. It also shows how men's pride blinds them from truth, while ~~some~~ women's observation and understanding uncover it. (Clas-

pell uses dramatic irony to highlight women's intelligence, sensitivity, and the injustice they face in a society that refuses to value their insight.

